CHAPTER TWENTY

Anti-Zionism in Contemporary Russia: Eurasian, Islamic, and Left-Populist Trends

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Although the Soviet regime never denied the right of the State of Israel to exist, anti-Zionism was an essential part of the state ideology from the late 1920s. It played no significant role until the late 1940s when, after short-term support of the plan to establish the Jewish state, the Soviet regime launched the wide-scale anti-Jewish campaigns camouflaged by anti-Zionist slogans. The campaigns halted after Stalin's death but the anti-Zionist trend revived and accelerated in the late 1960s following the Six-Day War and the USSR's cutting of diplomatic relations with Israel.

During Gorbachev's *Perestroika*, anti-Zionism ceased to be part of the state ideology but it was revealed as one of the basic elements in the ideologies of several right and left extremist movements that flourished under the "sun of democratization" alongside the severe economic crisis of the 1990s. Those marginal groups continued to exist and gain momentum in post-Soviet Russia.

Two factors influenced the development of anti-Zionism in the 1990s. First, there was the collapse of the Soviet Super Power state accompanied by economic disintegration and mass impoverishment. This led people to be more preoccupied with their permanent and imperative need to survive rather than with the situation in the Middle East. Second, the bloody Chechen War and attacks by Islamic terrorists inside Russia itself led the common citizens to an increased understanding and even sympathy for Israel. As a result, strident anti-Zionism served mainly as a euphemism for the imagined Jewish domination of Russian politics, the economy, and the media. It was significantly less focused on Israel, the Israeli-Palestinian or Israel-Arab conflict, inter-Palestinian relations, or the relations of various groups in the Muslim world. These issues returned to Russian political discourse in the last decade, and we can see in the writings and speeches of three thinkers who represent seemingly different trends that they have much more in common

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